

Seawall height in Hillsboro Beach

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

HILLSBORO BEACH • BROWARD COUNTY

5.0

ft NAVD88, max BFE (7.0 if BFE is 5.0)

New seawalls in Hillsboro Beach must have a top elevation of at least 5.0 ft NAVD88. The top generally may not be higher than the property's FEMA base flood elevation; where the BFE is 5.0 ft the maximum is 7.0 ft NAVD88. Walls must also be designed so they can be raised at least 24 inches later.

The detail

MINIMUM	5.0 ft NAVD88 for newly constructed seawalls - Code Sec. 12-268(D)
MAX (BFE OF 5.0 OR MORE)	the property's base flood elevation - Sec. 12-268(D) table
MAX (BFE EQUAL TO 5.0)	7.0 ft NAVD88 - Sec. 12-268(D)
MAX (X ZONE)	per the code's definition of grade (BFE for lowest floor on the FIRM) - Sec. 12-268(D)
WAIVER	Town Commission may allow lower walls where the habitable finished floor is below 5.0 ft NAVD88 - Sec. 12-268(D)
FUTURE RAISING	must be designed to be raised at least 24 in - Sec. 12-268(D)(6)
DOCKS	fixed docks max 10 in above the adjacent seawall - Sec. 12-268(D)(2)
WHY THE TOWN WROTE IT	King tides pushing Intracoastal water over State Road A-1-A, which closes the road - Sec. 12-268(A)
SEEPAGE HOLES	Where pressure relief is needed, walls must use seepage holes with backflow prevention or a valve with a backflow preventer, and must keep historic stormwater runoff patterns so adjacent roadways don't flood - Sec. 12-268(D)(1)
NEW HOMES PULL IN THE WALL	Any new single-family or multifamily construction, or loss of more than 50% of a building's floor area or replacement value, requires compliance - Sec. 12-268(D)(3)(a)

Where this comes from: Hillsboro Beach Code of Ordinances Ch. 12 (LDC), Art. XIII, Sec. 12-268 (Ords. 2017-294, 2020-05, 2021-05)

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.